

## **Max Weber introduction**

- Born April 21, 1864
- In Erfurt in Thuringia, Germany (Suburbs of Berlin)
- Eldest of seven children in upper middle class family
- German Political Economist and Sociologist
- One of the founders of modern Sociology
- Began his interest in Social Sciences when he was 13
- Brother Alfred became a Sociologist and Economist
- Helped found the German Democratic Party
- There are two main influencers to Max Weber's work:
- Karl Marx (1818-1883) and Emile Durkheim (1858-1917)
- The influence of Weber's parents stands out in his work. His mother's devout Calvinism probably encouraged Weber's study of world religions and his classic study of Calvinism and its impact on industrial capitalism, which we take up shortly

## **Theories of Max Weber**

- **Social action**
- **Verstehen**
- **Rationalization**
- **Authority**
- **Bureaucracy**

# Social action

## **Introduction:**

In sociology, social action, also known as weberian social action, is an act which takes into account the actions and reactions of individuals (or 'agents'). According to Max Weber, "Action is "social" insofar as its subjective meaning takes account of the behavior of others and is thereby oriented in its course.

- **According to Max Weber's action is social when**
  1. **Meaning attached to the action**
  2. **Action is consciously performed**
  3. **Action should be oriented towards other**
- **Social action theory is a micro perspective theory as the microcosms just eat eczema and smaller groups within society**

- **Social action theories see society as a product of human activities**
- Social action made up of two words social and action
- Social (something related to society)
- Action (process of doing something)

Definition:

Social action is an act activity which an individual performs within a society and there is a purpose behind it

## Types of social action

1. Traditional social action
2. Value rational social action
3. Effective social action
4. Goal rational social action

### **Traditional social action**

(Action that is custom or habit)

Traditional social action derived from the customs of society. Actions controlled by traditions, "the way it has always been done". This is an action which is guided by customs and long standing beliefs which become second nature or habit. In Pakistani Society doing 'Salam' to elders is almost second nature needing no prompting.

### **For example**

(buying a gift at Christmas)

if someone eats food with their bare hands and someone asks why are you not eating with fork and knife? If he/she replies that my ancestor used to eat with bare hands that's why I am eating too that way, such social action will come into the category of traditional social action.

### **Gold rational social action**

This type of social action is Goal oriented and the motive of the goal is derived from the desires of the actor. However, the goal should be realistic and actors should have means which are required to achieve the goal. In goal rational action; an individual sets a goal and he uses the efficient ways or means to achieve it. Moreover, the goal and the means should be rational or justifiable.

For example, an individual may want the highest score in the class, however, to accomplish that goal, he has to work hard and give more time to study and not let his emotions come in a way of

accomplishing his goal. If he does not give time to his studies and yet wants to score high in class then his goal and means of achieving it is considered to be irrational or unrealistic.

### **Value rational social action**

(Action towards a Goal the person regards as desirable)

In value rational social action, goal and means of achieving end is derived and determined by Values. This type of social action is also considered to be rational; however, the rationality of that action is justified by the actor from his set of beliefs, which may be aesthetic, religious, constitutional, and based on profession policy.

For example,

(Praying to get to heaven)

Individuals who are in the following professions, Police, clergy and lawyers are supposed to choose goals and means to accomplishing it, under a particular code and rules, which efficiency and effectiveness cannot be questioned by them.

### **Affective social action**

(Action that is expressed by an emotional state such as crying at funeral)

While the two types are dependent upon

rational systems (goal-oriented and value-oriented), this is considered the most irrational social action as it is motivated by the emotion of the individual. Such social action is motivated by the emotions of individuals. It is a sort of ready response to the behavior of others in terms of love, envy, hate, anger etc. In this type of social action actors don't think about consequences. Such actions are unplanned.

For Example, if a football player gets angry

During a match and in that moment of anger, he hits the opponent team player, he knows that such action will weaken their team position and may affect his career, despite knowing the consequences he hits the player. The reason why "weber" called it the most irrational social action.

## **Verstehen**

### **Introduction:**

Verstehen is a German word meaning understanding. From our point of view of action theory verstehen mean trying to understand the thought processes of the actor the actor's meanings and motives and how these factor led to the action

### **Social action and verstehen:**

Weber argued that before the cause of an action could be ascertained you had to understand the meaning attached to it by the individual. He distinguished between two types of understanding.

### **Aktuelles Verstehen**

First he referred to Aktuelles Verstehen - or direct observational understanding, where you just observe what people are doing. For example, it is possible to observe what people are doing - for example, you can observe someone chopping wood, or you can even ascertain (with reasonable certainty) someone's emotional state from their body language or facial expression. However, observational understanding alone is not sufficient to explain social action.

### **Eklarendes Verstehen**

The second type of understanding is Eklarendes Verstehen - or Empathetic Understanding - in which sociologists must try to understand the meaning of an act in terms of the motives that have given rise to it. This type of understanding would require you to find out why someone is chopping wood - Are they doing it because they need the firewood, are they just clearing a forest as part of their job, are they working off anger, just doing it

## **Rationalization**

### **Introduction**

Rationalization is a concept by a German sociologist known as Max Weber that endorses the substitution of traditions and values with rationality and logic. The goals of this concept are to enable people to understand each other and improve the self-esteem and self-concept of individuals

Personalization means thinking reasonably in a practical way

### **Definition**

Rationalization is the replacement of traditions, values, and emotions as motivators for behavior in society with concepts based on rationality and reason.

Weber was a very complex thinker who made many contributions to social thought, but his best known contribution is his grand theory of the increasing rationalization of the West. That theory is based on Weber's distinctions among four fundamental types of chin rationality

### **Principles**

**It refers to the process of transition to rationality built on four principles**

- **efficiency**
- **calculability**
- **predictability**
- **control**

## **Types of rationalization**

1. **Practical**
2. **Theoretical**
3. **Formal**
4. **Substantive**

### **Practical rationality**

There are four types of rationality as described by Max Weber

#### **Practical rationality**

Practical rationality involves systematically deciding the best way to achieve a desired end based on what is practical. Tasks and activities done in a practical way.

#### **Theoretical rationality**

involves understanding the world through abstract concepts. To understand the world around us deductively and inductively.

#### **Substitutive rationality**

involves deciding the best choice means to an end as guided by all of your collective values. Choosing between right and wrong based on our own values and morality.

#### **Formal rationality**

involves making choices based on universal rules, regulations and the larger structure of your society. Choosing between right and wrong based on rules and

## **Authority**

Authority means having the power to make others obey you. It is like being in charge and having the right to tell others what to do. Max Weber said that authority is when people agree to follow someone's rules or decisions. It is not the same as forcing people to do things, but rather getting them to do it willingly.

### **Definition**

According to Weber, Legitimate power is Authority.

### **Three types of authority**

Max Weber talked about three types of authority. Let's learn about each of them:

**Traditional authority**: Following Old Ways

Traditional authority is when people respect and obey someone because it has always been that way. It happens in societies where customs, traditions, or families decide who is in charge. For example, a king or queen might have traditional authority because their family has ruled for a long time.

**Legal rational authority:** Rules and Laws Guide Us

Legal-rational authority is when people follow someone's orders because there are rules and laws that say they have to. This type of authority happens in modern societies, like when we obey our teachers at school or the laws set by the government. It is all about following the rules and doing things fairly.

**Charismatic authority:** Inspiring Others with Special Qualities

Charismatic authority is when people are drawn to someone because of their special qualities or abilities. It's like having a magnet that attracts others. Charismatic leaders can inspire people to follow them because they have a unique vision or they are really good at something.

## **Bureaucracy**

A bureaucracy is an organization, whether publicly or privately owned, made up of several policymaking departments or units. People who work in bureaucracies are informally known as bureaucrats.

### Example of Bureaucracy

The hierarchical administrative structure of many governments is perhaps the most common example of a bureaucracy, the term can also describe the administrative structure of private-sector businesses or other non-governmental organizations, such as colleges and hospitals.

### **Theory of bureaucracy**

This theory focuses on the following two primary criteria:

- 1) Developing a hierarchical system in the organization;
- 2) Defining clear procedures, methods, rules, and regulations to carry out business operations and transactions.

Weber believed that there could be only three kinds of power in the organization:

1. Traditional authority
2. Legal rational authority

3. Charismatic authority

### **Principles of bureaucracy**

1. **Divino flavor**
2. **Authority hierarchy**
3. **Formal rules and regulation**
4. **Formal selection**
5. **Impersonality**
6. **Career Orientation**

### **Division Of Labor**

The whole work should be assorted into smaller task sets to ascertain that every set of tasks is assigned to the right person, i.e., the one who has the capability of fulfilling it. This not only improves the work efficiency but also ensures proper allocation of job responsibilities.

### **Hierarchy of authority**

Weber proposed that there should be a systematic hierarchy in the organization, defining the position of each employee from top to the lowest level. In such a system, each employee knows who they have to report, whose orders they need to follow, and what is the role of different personnel in the organization.

### **Formal Rules and Regulations**

There should be a clear set of principles, procedures, rules and regulations in written form, to be followed universally by everyone working in the organization irrespective of their position.

### **Impersonality**

In an organization, the impersonal relations develop among the employees, which may lead to favoritism or nepotism. Weber said that the application of rules and managerial decisions should be impartial and independent of such relations.

### **Career orientation**

Another essential principle is that management should motivate employees to build a long-term career in the organization by providing job security and performance-based incentives to them.

### **Former selection process**

Weber believed that the workers should be recruited through their technical skills and expertise instead of 'first come first selected' basis. Even the promotion should be based on performance and merit. This not only leads to better productivity but also adds to employee's growth and satisfaction Loadtor

### **Advantages**

- 1)** Specialization or Expertise
- 2) Skill-Based Recruitment
- 3) Predictability
- 4) Equality
- 5) Structure
- 6) Systematic Record Keeping
- 7) Rationality

### **Disadvantages**

- 1)** One way Communication
- 2) The exploitation of Power
- 3) Wastage of Time, Efforts and Money
- 4) Delay in Business Decision-Making
- 5) Hinders Innovation and Creativity
- 6) Inflexible and Rigid Methods